



Cover story Pakistan

Whether the Mumbai attacks were conducted by Islamist militants backed by Pakistan's military intelligence or by out-of-control "non-state actors" they have succeeded in at least one major respect. They have destabilised Pakistan's nascent democratic process and shifted the power dynamic to the right by hardening opinion against "Indian threats".

Not since 2004, when the current "peace process" began under General Musharraf, has public opinion been as united against the "external threat" from India, as opposed to the "internal threat" from religious

the Peshawar bomb blast last week that took the life of almost 30, as well as the recent strife in Karachi.

The shift in rhetoric has come about as a reaction to what has been perceived in Pakistan as the "irresponsible" blame-game of the Indian media post-Mumbai as well as the "aggressiveness" of the Indian Government. But the rhetoric from both sides plays well into the hands of actors who would like to move the focus away from the war against militancy in the areas around Afghanistan, as well as drive a wedge into the India-Pakistan peace process. It also re-establishes the



Inside Pakistan FEAR HOLDS THE KEY

With its nuke deterrent and the Afghan crisis, it fancies India can be kept at bay

extremists touted by Musharraf and the ruling Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) as the biggest challenge facing Pakistan. This shift was evidenced at the recently-concluded All Parties Conference, called by the government in the wake of the Mumbai attacks, which brought opposition hardliners such as the Jamaat-e-Islami's Qazi Hussain Ahmed, Tehrik-e-Insaaf's Imran Khan and the conservative Pakistan Muslim League (Q) on the same platform as the PPP, Nawaz Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League (N) and Fazlur Rehman's Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Islam. Even the militant Tehrik-e-Taliban, currently engaged in a fierce and bloody battle with the Pakistan Army in the north-west regions, in a sly move aimed at public sympathy, extended its support to the Pakistani state "in the case of an Indian attack". The change in mood is also in evidence from the public willingness to blame India for incidents such as

credibility of the military as the prime stake-holder in national security.

The military has been upset at the PPP's blundering attempts to cut it out of the loop on sensitive national security issues, and has long expressed its wariness over what it perceives as India's policy of "military encirclement" through its involvement in Afghanistan. In particular, it is also convinced of RAW funding and arms supplies for militancy in Balochistan and the tribal areas—which has taken over a thousand lives in the current year—and which has severely impacted Pakistan's investments and economy. It also perceives the US to be either "incredibly naïve" about Indian designs in the region or hand-in-glove with India in plans to dismember or neutralise Pakistan. The increasing involvement of Israel's Mossad in the training of the Indian Army has also fed this perception.

There has also been building frustration within Pakistan on India's

slow-tracking of resolution of issues such as Kashmir, Siachen and Sir Creek. With no movement on any of these fronts, questions were already being raised about the benefits to a peace process perceived as only buying time for India, almost exactly what India accuses Pakistan of.

So, what options does Pakistan have at the moment? The Pakistani establishment is relying on the critical stage of the NATO-led Afghanistan operation with the engagement of Pakistani forces in the north-west, as well as its own nuclear capability, to blunt the calls within India for war or even "surgical strikes". The Americans and NATO would be loathe to see Pakistan moving its 1,00,000 troops from the tribal areas to the east in the case of an attack by India. The threat to the war effort in the west has been driven home by recent Taliban attacks on NATO supply lines. A similar shift in focus after the 2001 attack on the Indian Parliament is